

Cut and colour



Amethyst mixed cut | This hexagonal gemstone has an unusual mixed cut consisting of a faceted pavilion and a cabochon-domed crown.



Step cut | The faceter of this square, step-cut, internally flawless amethyst has cleverly given a slight rounding to the corners to prevent chipping.



Mixed cut | This mixed-cut oval amethyst, with a brilliant cut crown and a step-cut pavilion, was cut with many tiny faces to disguise any colour variation within.



Milky quartz | Milky quartz is rarely faceted, but this intricate, brilliant oval cut adds an air of haunting mystery to the cloudy interior of the stone.



Fancy free-form amethyst | Cuts such as this 40.3-carat amethyst are known as "free-form" cuts: that is, the placement of the facets does not follow standard patterns.



Rock crystal | Faceted rock crystals were the original "rhinestones" – from quartz found in the Rhine. This brilliant cushion cut shows the "steeliness" of some stones.



Rose quartz | Facet-grade rose quartz is fairly uncommon; the detail of this briolette cut enhances the exceptional quality of the material, which is usually cloudy.

Amethyst in myth

Origins and superstitions

According to myth, amethyst was created by Bacchus, the Greek god of intoxication, wine, and grapes. He was pursuing a woman, Amethyste, who refused his affections and prayed to the gods to remain chaste. The goddess Diana responded, transforming Amethyste into a white stone. In shame, Bacchus poured a goblet of wine over the stone as an offering, dyeing its crystals purple. In Greek legend, amethyst is also said to ward off drunkenness, while medieval European soldiers wore it into battle, believing it had healing properties. The "blasted" Heron-Allen amethyst (right), meanwhile, is famously cursed.

**Heron-Allen amethyst**

This stone was said to bring misfortune to all who touched it.